

Commentary: Wagner, M. W. (2023). Independence by permission. *Science*, 381(6656), 388–391. <https://doi.org/10.1126/science.adi2430>

Wagner (2023), as the independent rapporteur, offers a thoughtful review of the project on the 2020 U.S. presidential election conducted by Meta and outside academics from the perspective of data ethics. Wagner recognizes that the project produced “rigorous, carefully checked, transparent, ethical, and path-breaking studies.” which were preregistered, and outside academics were unpaid by Meta, and scholars received “control rights” over interpretation and presentation of findings, which enhances the credibility and values of the findings. However, Wagner argues that Meta still controlled the raw data, the pace of collaboration, the boundaries of what could be studied, and research agenda, which shaped which papers were completed and published first. In the end, the author concluded that while the collaboration generated valuable and credible scholarship, it represented only “independence by permission,” because scholarship cannot be wholly independent when data are held by for-profit corporations, or when those corporations can limit the nature of what it can be studied.

I strongly agree with Wagner’s central argument that “independence by permission” is not independence. Wagner correctly argues that even though the studies were conducted ethically, sufficiently pre-registered, approved by multiple universities and independent institutional review board (IRB), and produced high-quality outcomes, this project cannot be a model for future collaborations, due to limited access to data and controlled research agenda by for-profit companies. I think this is especially relevant in platform research, where there is an asymmetrical power relation between outside academics and companies. Platforms such as Meta possess users’ behavioral data that no outside scholars can independently collect at the same scale. As long as they control the data, true independence cannot exist.

I also agree with Wagner’s concern that platform partnerships may privilege elite scholars while excluding less prestigious researchers. He notes that unpaid participation and reliance on prior Social Science One networks limited the access to a relatively select group. This raises issues of inequality within academia where prestigious scholars gain exclusive data opportunities, while junior scholars, researchers from the Global South, or those at teaching institutions may be left out. I totally agree with his warning that future academia could offer “incredible data and research opportunities to a select few” is troubling, that is, well-established scholars will become more advantaged through publishing more influential papers, while less well-resourced scholars become increasingly marginalized and excluded due to limited access to high-quality data.

However, I also think Wagner may underestimate the practical difficulty of balancing privacy with open access. His call for broader data sharing is normatively persuasive, but large-scale platform data often contain sensitive behavioral traces. Full access may create serious privacy risks, even though for the research purposes. Thus, the problem is not simply corporate withholding of data access, but designing secure governance systems that protect both transparency and user privacy.

Furthermore, I somewhat cannot deny the potential of collaborations between platforms and outside researchers. Even though platforms control the data access and what can be studied, such collaborations provide a lot of opportunities conducting large-scale and real-world research that would otherwise be impossible, generating valuable public knowledge, and improving transparency around how digital platforms shape people's social life. For instance, as mentioned in González et al. (2023) that the collaboration did not only enable outside researchers to analyze aggregated data of content with which users actively engaged through clicking, reacting, commenting, or sharing, but also the inventory of political news content users could potentially see and the subset of content actually shown in their Facebook feeds, which provided an opportunity to gain a nuanced understanding of how segregation varies with potential news consumption, actual exposure and engagement.

Critique and Response 1

González et al. (2023) examined whether Facebook promotes ideological segregation in political news exposure during the 2020 U.S. election. Using aggregated data from approximately 208 million U.S. Facebook users, the authors compare three stages of the “funnel of engagement”, including the political news users could potentially see, the content actually shown in their feeds after algorithmic curation, and the smaller subset of content with which they engaged through clicking, reacting, commenting, or sharing. Results showed that ideological segregation is substantial and increases from potential exposure to actual exposure and engagement. The study also found that conservative users were more likely to consume news in highly homogeneous information environments, while no equivalent liberal clusters were found. In addition, most misinformation identified by Meta's fact-checking program was concentrated within the conservative segment. The authors concluded that both platform algorithms and user behaviors contribute to ideological segregation, and Facebook's Pages and Groups play a particularly important role in amplifying ideologically compatible content.

Messing (2023) questions González et al. (2023) conclusion that Facebook's news feed algorithm increases ideological segregation. He argues that when segregation is measured at the more precise URL level rather than the broader domain level, there is little meaningful difference between the political content users could potentially see and the content actually shown after algorithmic ranking. He further cites the experiment comparing Facebook's ranked feed with a simple reverse chronological feed conducted by Guess et al. (2023), and found that ranking decreased exposure to like-minded political content and partisan news sources. Therefore, Messing (2023) concluded that feed ranking may have only limited effects on partisan segregation, while other recommendation systems, such as friend, page, and group recommendations, may play a more important role. In response, González et al. (2023) argued that Messing oversimplified their findings. They suggested that there were statistically significant increases in segregation in certain subsets, such as politically interested users, user-shared content, and Pages. They also emphasized that algorithmic curation especially promoted the homogeneous right-leaning “bubbles” after algorithmic ranking.

Looking from my perspective, this debate is theoretically meaningful because it shows that the effects of algorithms cannot be aggregated to a simple conclusion that algorithms either promote ideological segregation or have no impact at all. Messing (2023) reminds readers that measurement choices matter. Specifically, whether researchers analyze domains or specific URLs can lead to different conclusions, and this highlights the importance of methodological rigor when studying ideological segregation. His comparison with Guess et al. (2023) also suggests that algorithmic ranking may sometimes reduce exposure to ideologically homogeneous content relative to a simple reverse chronological feed. At the same time, González et al. (2023) argue that even though algorithmic ranking does not dramatically increase segregation across the whole sample, it may still intensify segregation among politically engaged users or promote homogeneous right-leaning content bubbles.

Furthermore, at the URL level, I cannot actually find significant evidence that algorithmic ranking substantially increases overall ideological segregation across the full sample from Figure 2C, while the effects may still be found in some subsamples. In large-scale platform studies with large sample size, even very small differences can become statistically significant, while their substantive effects on ideological segregation may remain limited. It may introduce another important question in evaluation of effects: does significance automatically mean meaningful effects, and should practical significance and effect size be given greater importance than statistical significance alone?